



AI AGENT COST REALITY

Quoted \$80K.
Spent \$340K.
Here is the gap.

Swipe →





THE COST GAP



Pilot cost is not production cost.

- Vendor quote is typically for POC, not production
- Inference at scale adds up fast beyond demo volume
- Compliance infra cost not included in vendor proposals
- Reviewer and escalation ops cost as much as the model





INFERENCE COST AT SCALE



Token costs multiply with production volume.

- Demo ran on 10K tokens per day at \$5 cost
- Production runs 2M tokens per day at \$1,200 cost
- Cost per interaction drops at volume but volume multiplies
- Model fine-tuning cycles add significant one-time costs





COMPLIANCE INFRA COST



Audit trail and governance: not free.

- Audit log storage and querying: \$2K-8K/month
- Compliance monitoring tooling: \$3K-12K/month
- Security review and pen test: \$15K-40K one-time
- Model risk management documentation:
significant eng time





REVIEWER OPS COST



Human review is a cost line item.

- Reviewer queue staffing: \$8K-25K/month depending on volume
- Training and quality assurance for reviewers
- Escalation management and decision logging
- Reviewer ops often equals or exceeds model inference cost





REAL COST BREAKDOWN



What \$340K actually bought.

- Model inference at production scale: \$85K
- Compliance infrastructure build and tooling: \$60K
- Security review, audit, and penetration testing: \$35K
- Reviewer operations over six months: \$95K
- Engineering overhead and iteration: \$65K





COST OPTIMIZATION



Where to cut without cutting corners.

- Model right-sizing: use smallest model that meets accuracy requirement
- Caching frequent queries: reduces inference cost 30-60%
- Batch processing where latency allows: cuts cost per token
- Reviewer queue optimization: better routing = fewer reviews





3x the vendor quote for production.

- Vendor POC quote x 3 = realistic first-year production budget
- Model inference: 20-30% of total
- Compliance and security: 25-35% of total
- Operations and reviewer queue: 30-40% of total





CODISTE AI

Get an honest cost estimate.

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